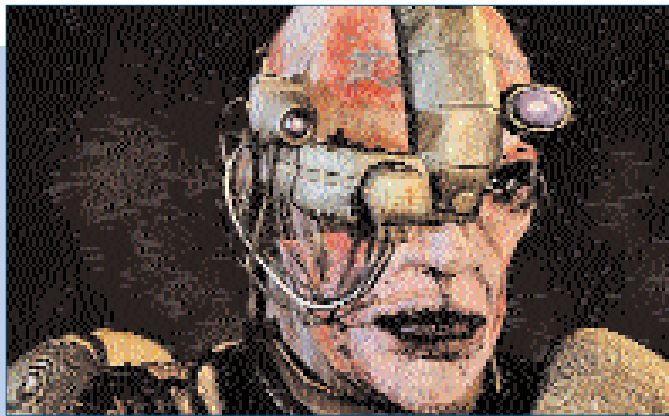




A typical, very representative artist's impression of what a half-human, half-machine organism will look like. Augmentation of the senses is a crucial feature of such impressions

a world where
one needs to
do nothing,
simply experi-
encing, with
five senses or
more, rich
worlds we
cannot even
describe today?

Such will be the temptation that will face the cyborg.

Who will have power over them? What will the politics of such a situa-

tion be like? There are no clear answers.

The rush to converge with machines may have benign motivations: a longer, healthier life, free from disease and pain. But there are hidden dangers that need serious looking-into.

Reality

Thus far, we have spoken as though the ideal cyborg form is indeed achievable. It may be. But receiving an implant is no simple matter. Warwick and others have proved that simple implants do, in fact, pose no long-term problems. But what of more complex ones, those that interface with the nervous system? We just don't know yet.

In fact, the order of the day is unanswered questions. What does it mean to ‘experience’ ultrasonics? Is direct-thought communication really possible? Will implants, in fact, successfully interface with the brain, with its billions of neurons? We do not entirely understand memory; how can we assume that memory augmentation is possible via implants?

The demand for augmentation will certainly be there when the time is ripe. As of today, human cloning is banned, but is a very real possibility. And what an immense demand for human cloning would be there if and when it were legalised!

In the same way, when implants that interface with the nervous system become available, there will be tremendous demand. It will first be for medical reasons, as in restoring sight to the blind. Then there will be the experimenters—those who will treat such implants as a method of toying with the boundaries of experience.

Given the socio-economic divides of today, not everyone will have access to them. However, the experiences of a few will be sufficient to prove the concept, and make it known what it is like to be a 'true cyborg'. What happens if those first reports turn out to be positive?

Whither Mankind?

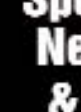
Warwick and others maintain that cyborgdom is the next, natural step in our evolution. This, they say, is because we are creating machines more powerful than ourselves, and the only way to keep up if they jostled for power with us would be to merge with them. This, of course, assumes that the machines will have a will of their own, that they will want to dominate. If that ever becomes the case, turning cyborg will be the only way to go!

There are other compelling forces that will drive humanity the cyborg way: the sheer desire on mankind's part, as we said at the outset, to overcome our inherent limitations. The desire to cure all disease permanently, to forever negate Adam's sin and not have to work any more. The promise, thus, of a utopian existence.

What direction humanity will take will be determined only after the first 'real' experiments. It's then that we'll know what will happen to mankind, to cyborgdom. We can only hope that we learn a lot more about what it is to be human before that day arrives. ■

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Given the socio-economic divides of today, not everyone will have access to implants that interface with the nervous system


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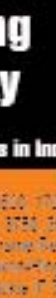
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